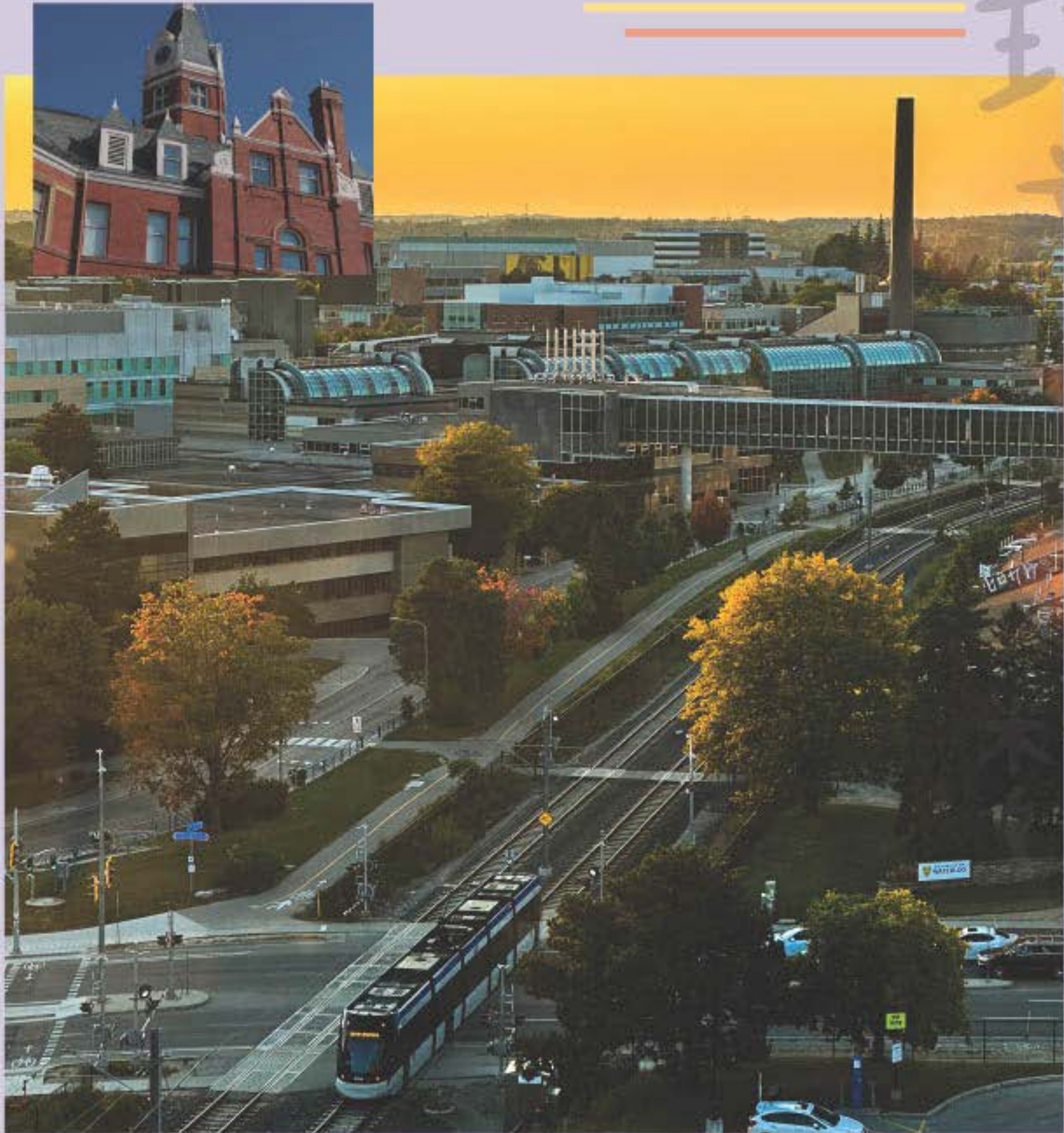


GBDA 101



Global Business and
Digital Arts, Fall 2024
Course. Year 1

Stratford School of
Interaction Design
and Business at the
University of Waterloo

Created by: Joyce Fan
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Introduction

At the beginning of this course, my understanding of design was heavily rooted in aesthetics. My background in high school, where I spent four years in the yearbook club and visual arts council, gave me experience in layout design using tools like eDesign and Canva. However, my exposure to professional design platforms like Adobe InDesign and Premiere Pro was limited. I also studied visual arts in an art school, which gave me a foundation in traditional, non-traditional, and digital arts. Entering this course, I believed I had a solid grasp of design principles but quickly realized how much more there was to learn. I viewed design as primarily visual but came to understand its broader role in problem-solving, storytelling, and creating emotional experiences.



Evolution of Creative Process

One of the most significant changes in my creative process was moving from a purely aesthetic approach to one that prioritized functionality, emotional impact, and user interaction. For instance, when designing a product that conveyed delight, I initially focused on its visual appeal but gradually incorporated surprise elements, like motivational actions and an unexpected appearance of friends in a video.

I also learned to prototype systematically, starting with low-fidelity sketches and testing ideas before refining them. A memorable example was creating icons for my dice, the use of typography, and how to convey an emotion. While these designs appeared simple, they were sourced in careful sketching, feedback, and revisions. Incorporating diverse influences expanded my creative boundaries.



Course Theme and Principles

Among the themes explored, emotional design had the most profound impact on my perspective. Understanding how design can evoke feelings transformed the way I approach projects. The assignment on creating a delight-focused product demonstrating this; I used uplifting illustrations, surprise elements, and interactive features to create an immersive and joyful experience. Design principles such as alignment, contrast, and hierarchy revolutionized my approach. In a typographic layout project, I discovered how manipulating scale, and white space could improve readability and convey meaning. Applying these principles enhanced the clarity and cohesiveness of my work. For example, in the branding project where we were to make icons for objects, I used color harmony to create visually appealing drink icons by incorporating colors like red from Yakult and green from Vita Lemon Tea into cohesive pastel palettes.



Challenges and Solutions

The course was not without its challenges. For instance, I struggled with adhesive issues while constructing prototypes, eventually settling on hot glue, which gave my project a handmade aesthetic. Painting delicate details like bunnies tested my patience, but I adjusted the paint's consistency to achieve the desired effect. In technical tasks, issues like clipping masks in Illustrator initially frustrated me. However, I turned to online tutorials and resources, using creative solutions like strategically placed shapes to make a cleaner look. These challenges taught me resilience and the importance of leveraging available tools and knowledge. What I learned from this course and my previous mentors is that mastering Adobe is incredibly powerful, as it is a widely used platform across industries.



Skills and Tools

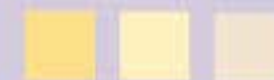
This course dramatically enhanced my knowledge with tools like Adobe Illustrator, InDesign, Premiere Pro and Photoshop. One of my proudest achievements during this course was creating a product video that showcased an emotional design concept. Starting with a paper prototype, I iteratively improved my designs by incorporating feedback from my peers and friends.

Another highlight was learning to create mock-ups. Using Illustrator and Photoshop, I photographed real-world objects, added logos, and blended designs seamlessly, creating a mock-up of the product. These techniques bridged the gap between conceptual ideas and practical applications, making my designs more impactful and professional to showcase for future businesses.





Collecting real-world inspirations enhanced my awareness of design in everyday spaces.



Typography



Typography fascinates me because it conveys so much about a design through the choice of fonts, spacing, and arrangement. Whether it's a logo, magazine cover, or sign, typography helps communicate a brand's identity and message. I'm drawn to how different typefaces can evoke different emotions, like bold fonts showing strength or elegant serifs feeling more sophisticated. I enjoy experimenting with type in my designs, especially when considering how to balance readability and emotion.



Pattern



Patterns, both natural and artificial, inspire me because they create rhythm and interest in a design. I've noticed how geometric patterns like buildings and staircases offer structure, while organic patterns, like leaves or the northern lights feel more free flowing. I appreciate how both types of patterns can work together in a design, guiding the viewer's eye and creating a balanced, cohesive look. I want to explore how to use these contrasting patterns in my own designs to create visual harmony.



2D Design



I'm also inspired by 2D designs, like posters, illustrations, and murals. These designs use color, composition, and form to grab attention and communicate a message. I find it fascinating how a simple poster can convey a story, or how an illustration reflects the mood of the design. I've seen how bold colors and creative layouts can transform a space, like in vibrant murals. These designs have taught me how small details, like placement and color, can greatly impact the viewer's experience.



Future Directions

Looking ahead, I am eager to explore deeper into UX design, branding, and videography. This course taught me to think critically about user interaction, making me excited to explore how digital interfaces shape experiences. The skills I've acquired will undoubtedly enhance my academic projects and future career, preparing me to create designs that are not only visually appealing but also meaningful and impactful. This course has been a transformative journey, shifting my perception of design and equipping me with the tools to create with purpose. I now approach and view every project with a deeper understanding of its potential to influence, connect, and delight.

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